A DIVIDED FRATERNITY

WHEN THE LAW PROMOTES GENERICS

Though retracted, mandatory generic prescriptions would mean...



- Doctors have to prescribe only unbranded generic medicines
- A pharmacist, not a doctor, decides which company's medicine a patient should buy
- Reduction in costs, as unbranded generics are nearly 30-80 per cent cheaper, but dubious quality

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT IS DOING

Several measures are being taken to improve medical manufacture

- All producers expected to comply with revised good manufacturing practices within the next 12 months
- Extensive quality control in place for 1,800 unbranded generic medicines sold at Jan Aushadhi outlets
- Medicines sold at Jan Aushadhis saved an estimated Rs 7,000 crore in expenses last year



NOT GOOD ENOUGH FOR DOCTORS

They are wary of their poor quality, ineffectiveness, and side-effects

- The world leader in generic drugs, India produces over 60,000 such medicines across 60 categories
- Around 10,500 drug manufacturing units in India; around 8,500 units come under the MSME category, of which only 2,000 have WHO GMP certification



- Less than 0.1 per cent of Indian generic drugs are tested for quality
- Central Drug Standard Control Organization identified nearly 4.5 per cent of all generic drugs in India as substandard

promoting generic medicines—which are often 30 per cent to 80 per cent cheaper than their branded equivalents—the NMC hopes to reduce the cost of treatment in the country.

The now-withdrawn NMC guideline also asked doctors to encourage patients to purchase medicines from government-run Jan Aushadhi Kendras and other generic pharmacy outlets. India is the world's largest producer and exporter of generic drugs, with medicines worth over £17 billion (Rs 1.76 lakh crore) exported last year.



DR SHARAD KUMAR
President, Indian Medical Association

> "THERE ARE THOUSANDS OF SMALL COMPANIES WHO MANUFACTURE THE SAME SALT AS A BRANDED MEDICINE BUT THESE COMPLETELY LACK INFRASTRUCTURE AND TECHNICAL KNOWHOW FOR QUALITY CONTROL AND TESTING"

NOT TRUSTED BY DOCTORS

Non-branded generic drugs are yet to win the confidence of doctors. Most say that the effectiveness and reliability of such medicines are hard to ascertain due to a lack of batch testing and the prevalence of haphazard approval procedures. "There are thousands of small firms who manufacture the same salt as a branded medicine but these completely lack infrastructure and technical knowhow for quality control and testing. If every single batch of an unbranded generic was tested, the way branded ones are, then that instils faith," says IMA president Dr Sharad Kumar.

According to data from the Union ministry of chemicals and fertilisers, India produces over 60,000 generic drugs across 60 therapeutic categories, manufactured by 3,000 firms in over 10,500 units. However, there is no current data showing the number of small units producing generic medicine.

But, according to T.V. Narayana, president of Indian Pharmaceutical Association, the rise of e-pharmacies has significantly inflated the figure. "There is tremendous potential for pharmaceutical manufacturing in India. And the demand for India-made generics is high. But as supply increases it is important to enforce regular quality and compliance checks regardless of company size," he says.

According to IMA estimates, less than 0.1 per cent of generic drugs in India are tested for quality. In 2018, the Central Drug Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) estimated that